

THE **Five Before Five Book List**

A curated ecosystem of books to strengthen your mindset, deepen your faith, guide your personal growth, and prepare you to get in to the college of your dreams.





Bismillah!

At Five Before College, we believe the most powerful advantage a young person can build isn't a test score, a GPA, or a résumé line — it's who they become. These years before adulthood are the training ground where identity, discipline, purpose, and character take shape.

The Prophet ﷺ taught us to take advantage of five before five — youth before old age, health before sickness, wealth before poverty, free time before busyness, and life before death. These priorities form the foundation of our program and the structure of this reading guide.

This resource is more than just a random list of books. It is a curated roadmap designed to help you — the student — think deeply, grow intentionally, and build habits that give you an edge in every part of your life. Whether you're strengthening your mindset, improving your health, learning how money works, focusing your time, or understanding your purpose, these resources are chosen to support your journey with clarity and barakah.

Every recommendation here was selected because it can help you:

- Sharpen your mind
- Strengthen your habits
- Understand yourself
- Build identity and confidence
- Make wiser decisions
- Grow spiritually
- And expand what you believe is possible

This guide is for you to keep, return to, and use as you grow. Parents, mentors, and teachers are welcome to follow along too — these ideas spark meaningful conversations at home and help everyone support the student's path.

May Allah place barakah in your effort, your learning, and the person you are becoming.

Was-salaam,

Hamzah Henshaw

Br. Hamzah Henshaw
& the Five Before College Team

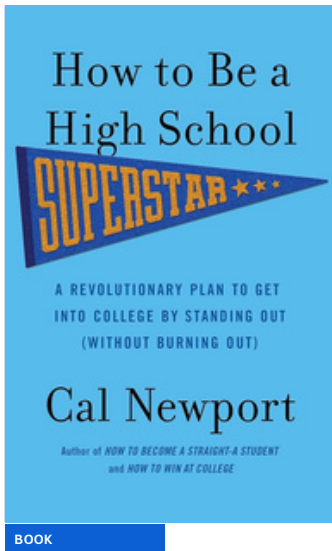
PART 1:

**YOUTH BEFORE
OLD AGE**



YOUTH BEFORE OLD AGE

Academics • Intellectual Curiosity • Identity • Purpose

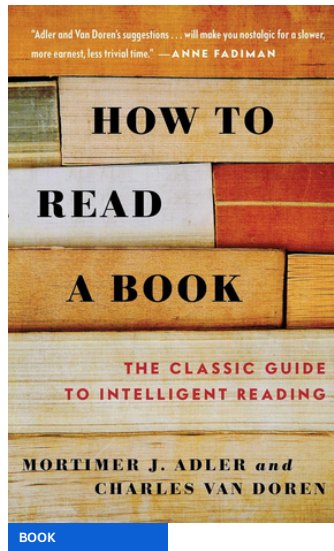


HOW TO BE A HIGH SCHOOL SUPERSTAR

Cal Newport

A blueprint for standing out in high school by doing fewer things better; the origin of the Saturday Morning Project idea

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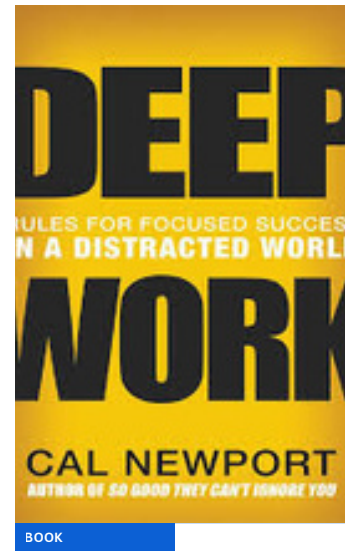


HOW TO READ A BOOK

Mortimer Adler

Classic guide to reading with depth and intellectual rigor.

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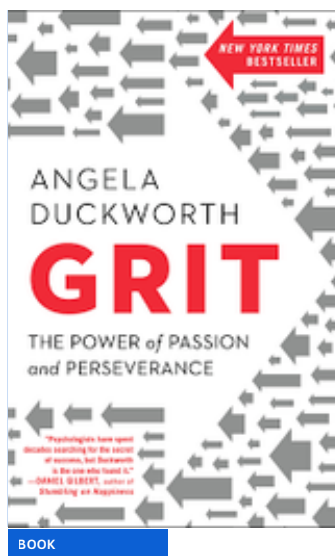


DEEP WORK

Cal Newport

A framework for mastering hard skills through intense, distraction-free focus.

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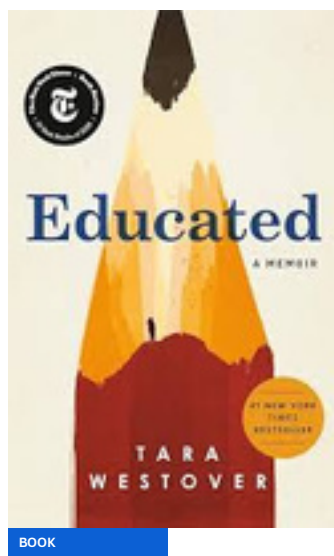


GRIT

Angela Duckworth

Why perseverance and passion matter more than talent.

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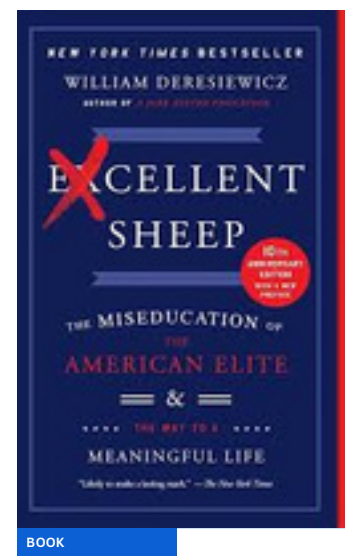


EDUCATED

Tara Westover

Memoir of overcoming extreme educational disadvantage through willpower and curiosity.

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EXCELLENT SHEEP

William Deresiewicz

A sharp critique of elite education and resume-driven adolescence

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YOUTH BEFORE OLD AGE

Academics • Intellectual Curiosity • Identity • Purpose



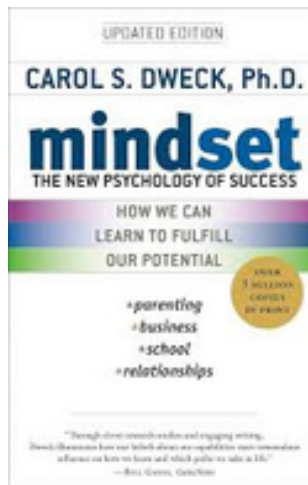
BOOK

MASTERY

Robert Greene

How extraordinary individuals achieve world-class skill over time.

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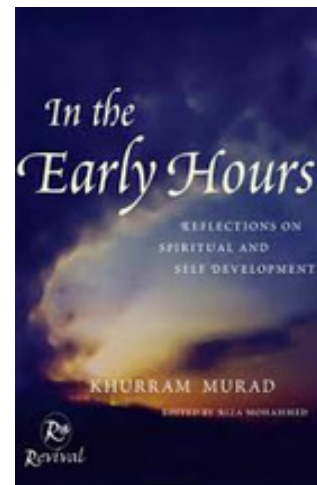
BOOK

MINDSET

Carol Dweck

The science of shifting from a fixed mindset to a growth mindset.

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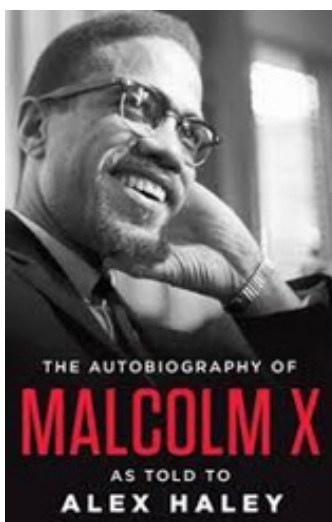
BOOK

IN THE EARLY HOURS

Khurram Murad

Short Islamic guide to intentional living and seeking knowledge in youth.

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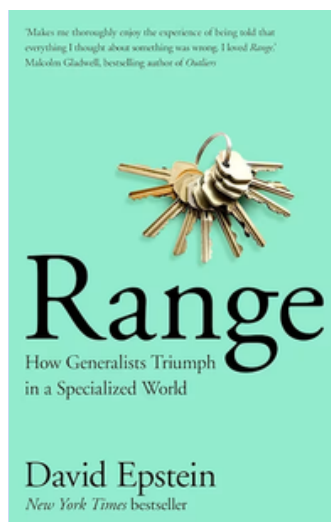
BOOK

THE AUTOBIOGRAPHY OF MALCOLM X

Malcolm X & Alex Haley

A transformational journey of identity, justice, and awakening.

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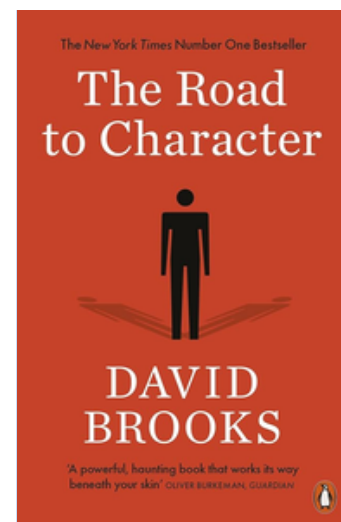
BOOK

RANGE

David Epstein

Challenges early specialization and shows how curiosity, experimentation, and broad learning lead to deeper insight, creativity, and long-term success.

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BOOK

THE ROAD TO CHARACTER

David Brooks

Explores the difference between résumé virtues and character virtues, urging young people to build identity, humility, and moral depth alongside achievement.

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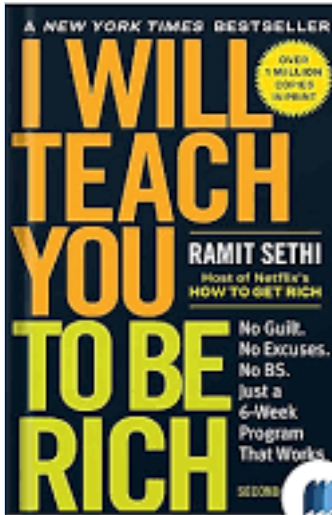
PART 2:

**WEALTH BEFORE
POVERTY**



WEALTH BEFORE POVERTY

Money • Career • Internships • Barakah in Wealth



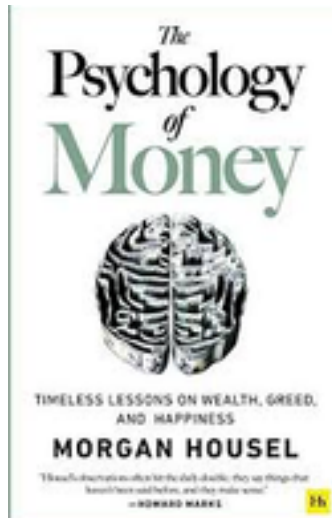
BOOK

I WILL TEACH YOU TO BE RICH

Ramit Sethi

Straightforward system for saving, investing, and budgeting.

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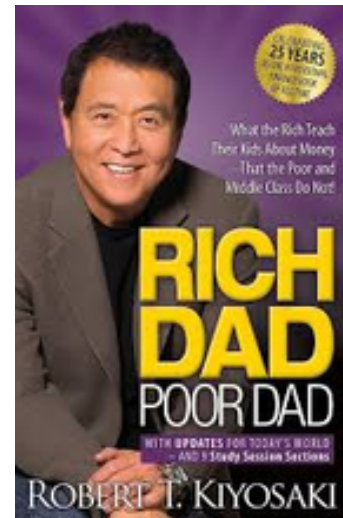
BOOK

THE PSYCHOLOGY OF MONEY

Morgan Housel

How emotions, behavior, and humility shape financial outcomes.

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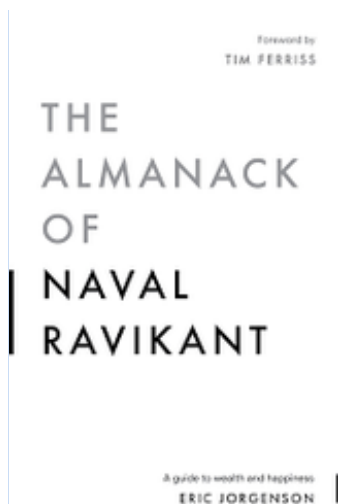
BOOK

RICH DAD POOR DAD

Robert Kiyosaki

Intro to assets, liabilities, and entrepreneurial thinking.

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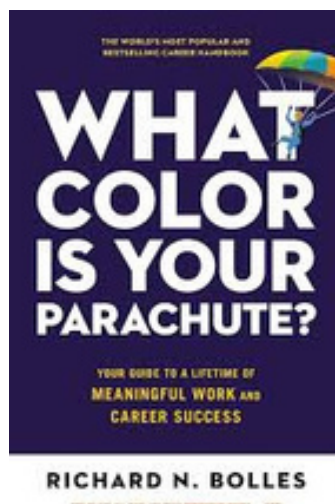
BOOK

THE ALMANACK OF NAVAL RAVIKANT

Eric Jorgenson

Distilled wisdom on wealth, leverage, and freedom.

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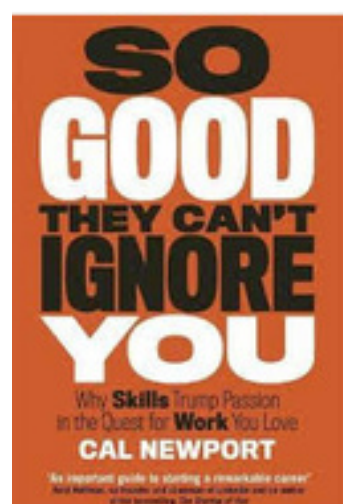
BOOK

WHAT COLOR IS YOUR PARACHUTE?

Richard Bolles

A values-centered guide to vocational calling that helps students discern the kind of life they want to lead.

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BOOK

SO GOOD THEY CAN'T IGNORE YOU

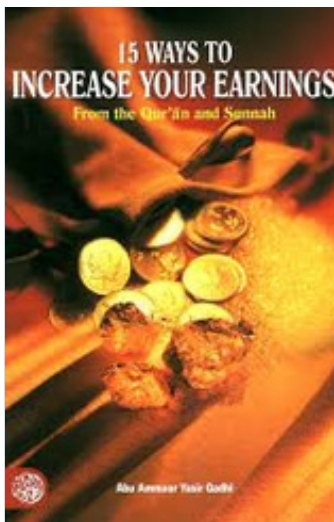
Cal Newport

Why skill-building leads to fulfilling careers.

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WEALTH BEFORE POVERTY

Money • Career • Internships • Barakah in Wealth

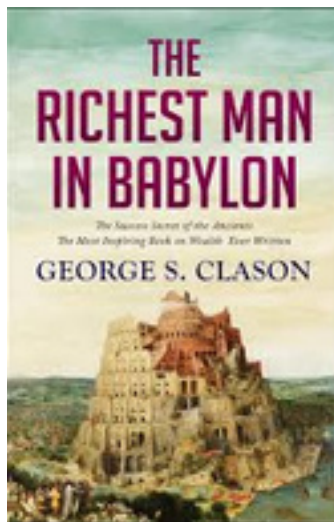


BOOK

15 WAYS TO INCREASE YOUR EARNINGS (ISLAMIC) Yasir Qadhi

Quranic and Prophetic principles for barakah in income.

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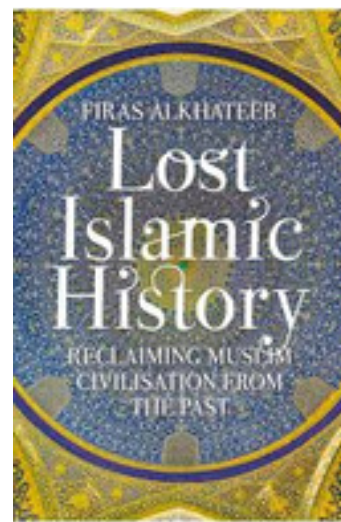


BOOK

THE RICHEST MAN IN BABYLON George Clason

Timeless parables on saving and investing.

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BOOK

LOST ISLAMIC HISTORY Firas Alkhateeb

Shows how Muslims historically excelled in trade, innovation, and thriving civilizations.

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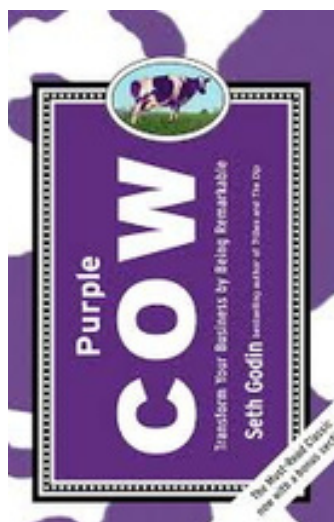
BOOK

\$100M OFFERS

Alex Hormozi

A clear, structured framework for understanding value creation and designing irresistible offers.

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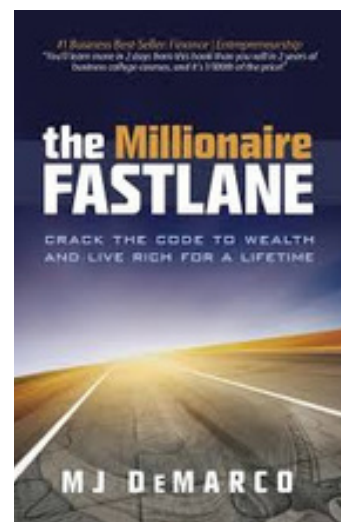
BOOK

PURPLE COW

Seth Godin

Shows why standing out matters and teaches students how to differentiate themselves and their work.

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BOOK

THE MILLIONAIRE FASTLANE

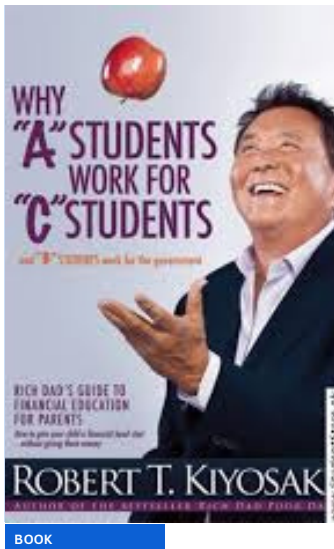
MJ DeMarco

A contrarian take on wealth-building that encourages entrepreneurship and scalable thinking.

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WEALTH BEFORE POVERTY

Money • Career • Internships • Barakah in Wealth



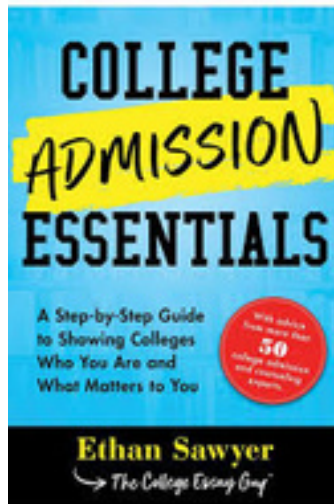
BOOK

WHY A STUDENTS WORK FOR C STUDENTS

Robert Kiyosaki

Challenges conventional schooling and promotes financial literacy, ownership, and entrepreneurial skill.

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BOOK

COLLEGE ADMISSION ESSENTIALS

Ethan Sawyer

A practical, teen-friendly guide to writing standout essays and navigating the college application process with clarity.

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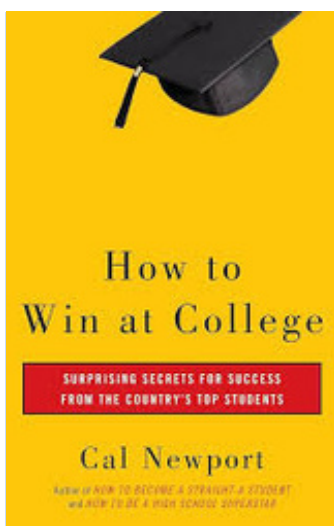
BOOK

FISKE GUIDE TO COLLEGES

Edward Fiske

A trusted, comprehensive resource that helps families compare colleges realistically and build thoughtful lists.

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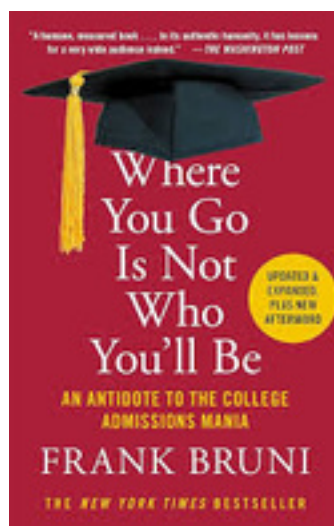
BOOK

HOW TO WIN AT COLLEGE

Cal Newport

A playbook of small, actionable habits that help students thrive academically and socially in college.

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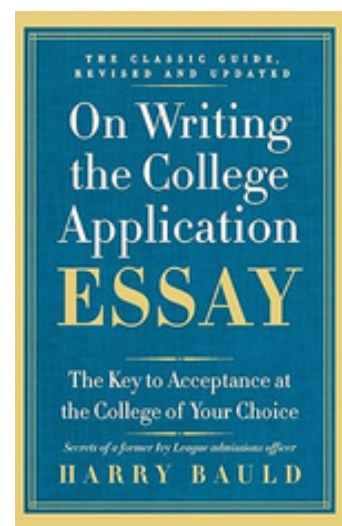
BOOK

WHERE YOU GO IS NOT WHO YOU'LL BE

Frank Bruni

A needed antidote to prestige obsession, reminding students that their future is shaped by effort and mindset, not brand names.

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BOOK

ON WRITING THE COLLEGE APPLICATION ESSAY

Harry Bauld

A clear, humane guide to writing authentic college essays that emphasize voice, reflection, and self-understanding over gimmicks or résumé repetition.

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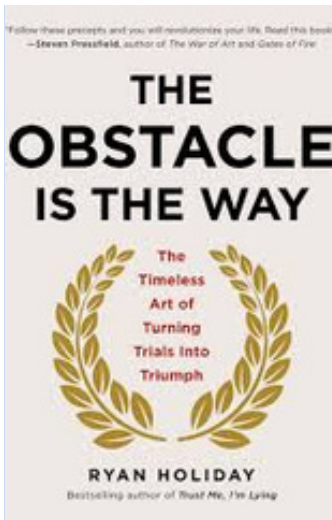
PART 3:

**HEALTH BEFORE
SICKNESS**



HEALTH BEFORE SICKNESS

Physical Health • Mental Health • Habits • Resilience



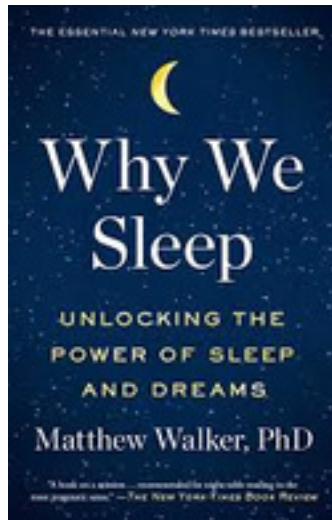
BOOK

THE OBSTACLE IS THE WAY

Ryan Holiday

Stoic tools for reframing setbacks into strength.

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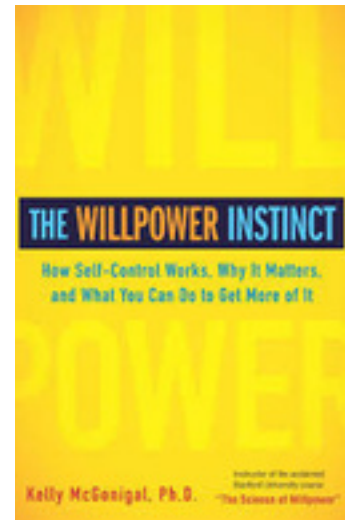
BOOK

WHY WE SLEEP

Matthew Walker

How sleep fuels learning, memory, mood, and long-term health.

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BOOK

THE WILLPOWER INSTINCT

Kelly McGonigal

The science of self-control and motivation.

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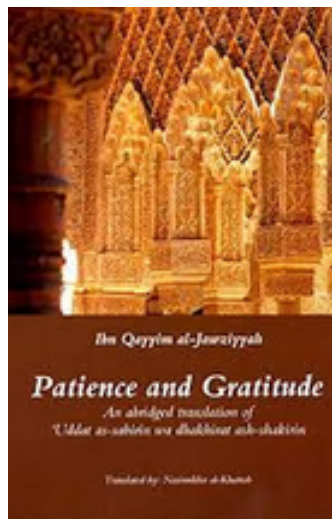
BOOK

DON'T BE SAD

Aaidh al-Qarni

Islamic guidance for managing sadness, hardship, and anxiety.

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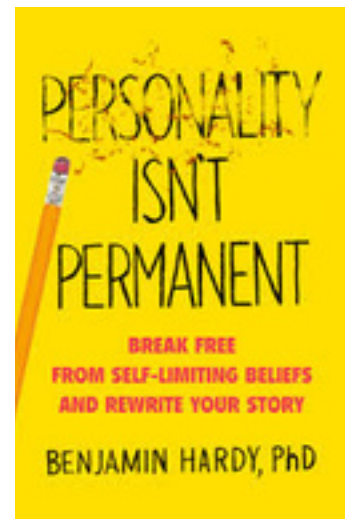
BOOK

PATIENCE AND GRATITUDE

Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyya

Classical teachings on emotional resilience.

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BOOK

PERSONALITY ISN'T PERMANENT

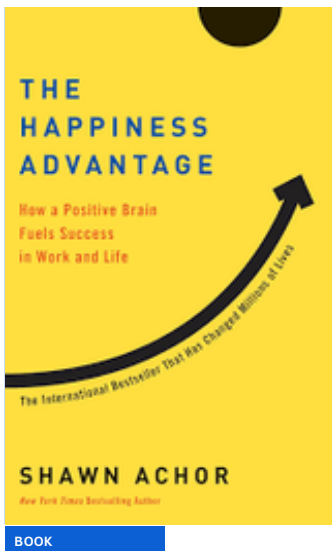
Benjamin Hardy

Argues that identity is flexible and self-authored, empowering students to become who they choose to be.

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HEALTH BEFORE SICKNESS

Physical Health • Mental Health • Habits • Resilience

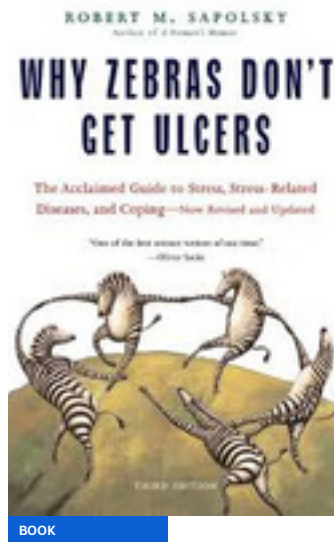


THE HAPPINESS ADVANTAGE

Shawn Achor

Demonstrates that cultivating positive emotions enhances performance, learning, and resilience.

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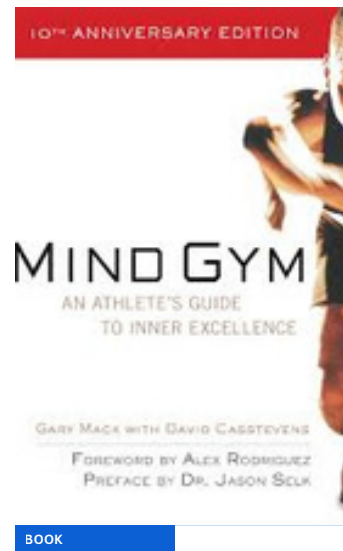


WHY ZEBRAS DON'T GET ULCERS

Robert Sapolsky

A classic, science-first explanation of stress physiology and its downstream effects on the body, from immune function to chronic disease.

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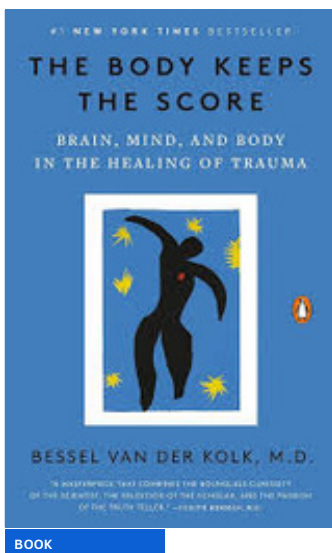


MIND GYM

Gary Mack

Mental training techniques drawn from elite athletics, emphasizing and performance under pressure.

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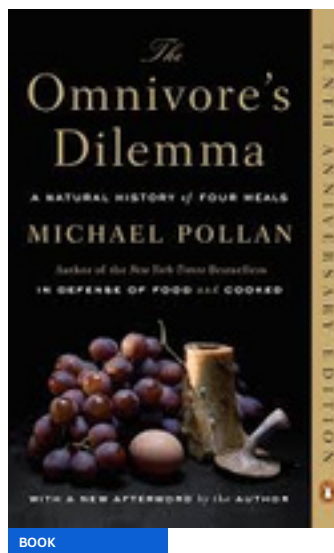


THE BODY KEEPS THE SCORE

Bessel van der Kolk

How trauma and chronic stress live in the body, shaping physical health, behavior, and healing; foundational for understanding mind-body integration.

[Shop Amazon](#)



THE OMNIVORE'S DILEMMA

Michael Pollan

A timeless lens on food systems, industrial vs natural eating, and moral clarity around nutrition without micromanaging macros.

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THE ART OF REST

Claudia Hammond

A serious look at rest, recovery, and parasympathetic health in a culture that over-indexes productivity.

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PART 4:

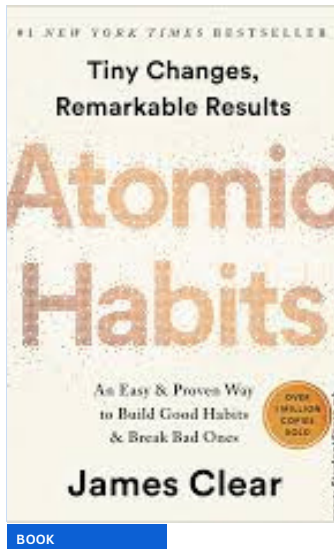
FREE TIME BEFORE

BUSYNESS



FREE TIME BEFORE BUSYNESS

Productivity • Hobbies • Flow • Friendship • Focus

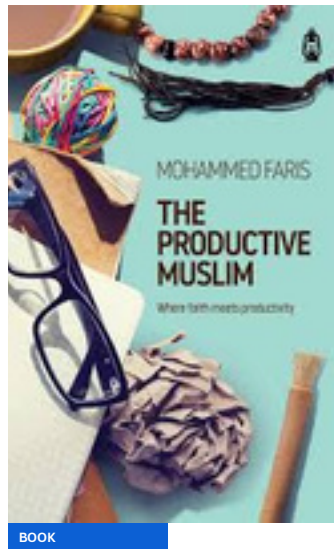


ATOMIC HABITS

James Clear

Systems for building good habits and eliminating bad ones.

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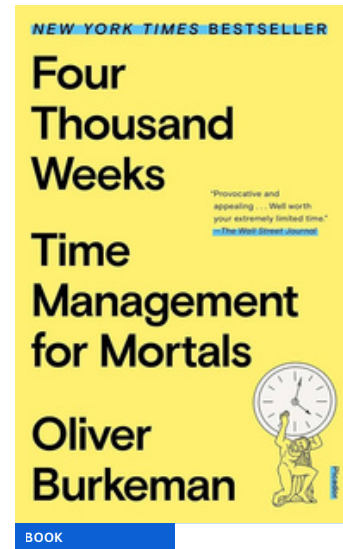


THE PRODUCTIVE MUSLIM

Mohammed Faris

Merges Islamic spirituality with modern productivity and wellbeing.

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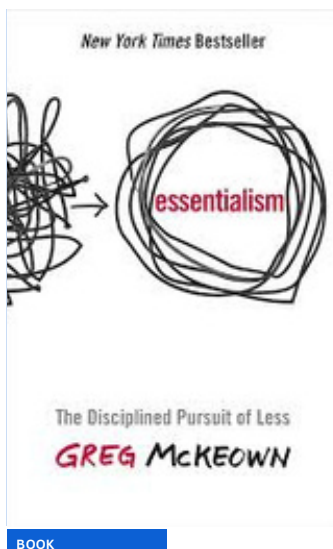


FOUR THOUSAND WEEKS

Oliver Burkeman

A reality-reset on using finite time wisely.

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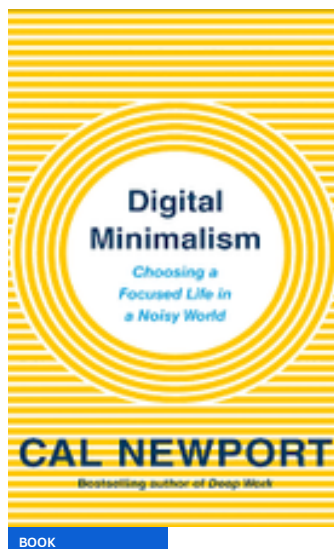


ESSENTIALISM

Greg McKeown

Choose the vital few over the trivial many.

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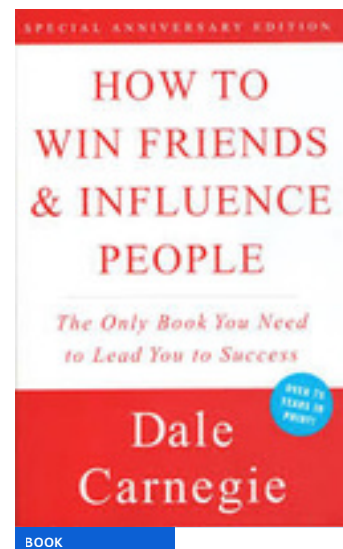


DIGITAL MINIMALISM

Cal Newport

Reclaim attention from devices and rebuild meaningful leisure.

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HOW TO WIN FRIENDS AND INFLUENCE PEOPLE

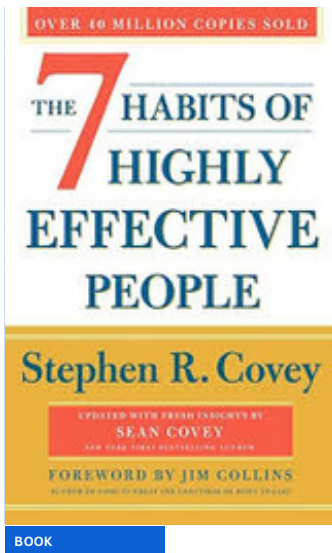
Dale Carnegie

Classic human behavior and communication skills.

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FREE TIME BEFORE BUSYNESS

Productivity • Hobbies • Flow • Friendship • Focus



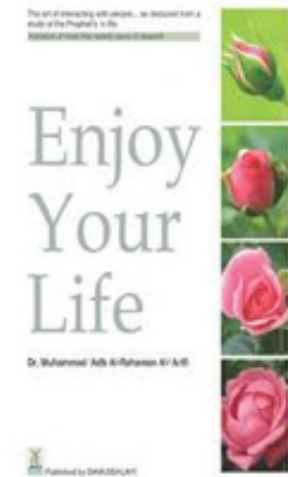
BOOK

THE 7 HABITS OF HIGHLY EFFECTIVE PEOPLE

Stephen Covey

A balanced framework for personal leadership.

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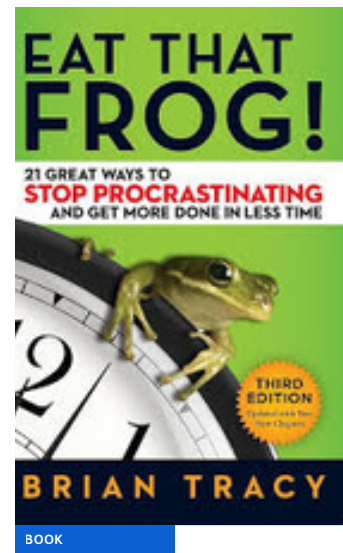
BOOK

ENJOY YOUR LIFE

Muhammad Al-'Arifi

Prophetic lessons on people skills, joy, and intentionality.

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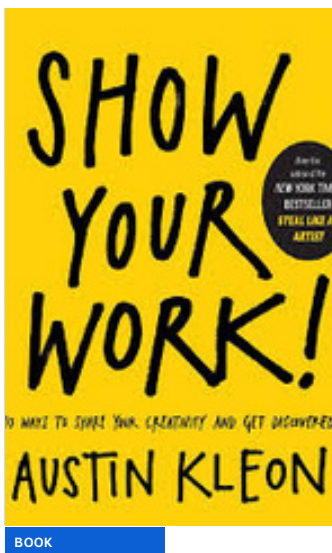
BOOK

EAT THAT FROG!

Brian Tracy

Practical strategies for beating procrastination.

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BOOK

SHOW YOUR WORK!

Austin Kleon

Encourages students to share their creative process and build a visible body of work.

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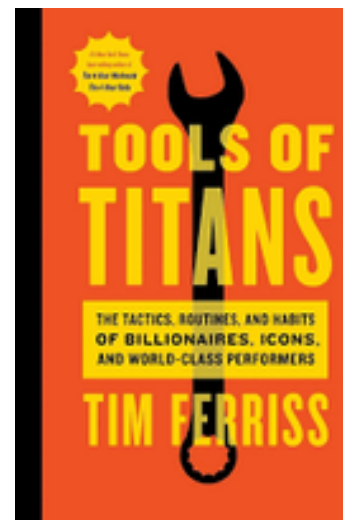
BOOK

THE CHECKLIST MANIFESTO

Atul Gawande

Demonstrates how simple checklists create reliability, reduce mistakes, and improve performance.

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BOOK

TOOLS OF TITANS

Tim Ferriss

Compiles the habits and routines of world-class performers across health, wealth, and productivity.

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PART 5:

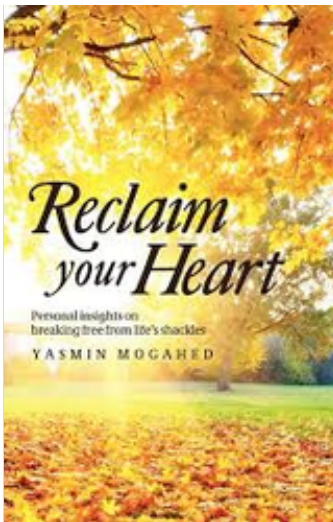
LIFE BEFORE

DEATH



LIFE BEFORE DEATH

Spirituality • Mortality • Legacy • Character



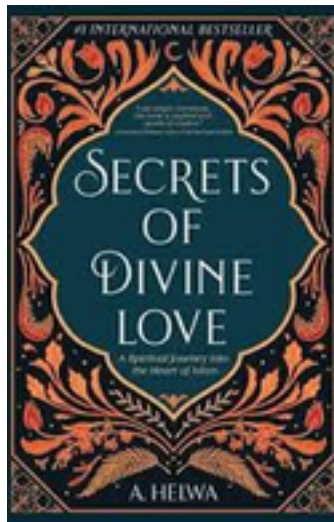
BOOK

RECLAIM YOUR HEART

Yasmin Mogahed

On freeing the heart from unhealthy attachments and returning it to Allah.

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BOOK

SECRETS OF DIVINE LOVE

– A. Helwa

A warm, accessible introduction to Islamic spirituality.

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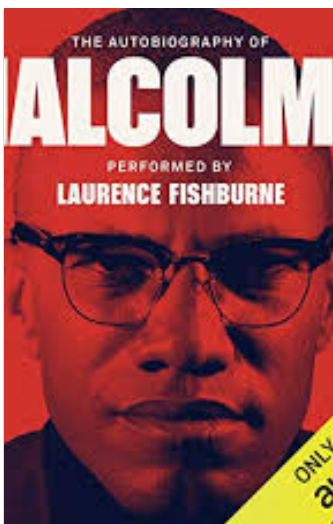
BOOK

ALLAH LOVES

Omar Suleiman

Short reflections on qualities beloved to Allah.

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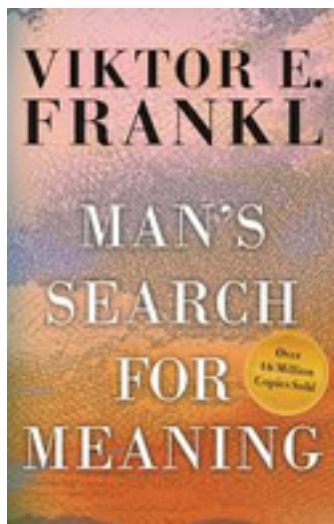
BOOK

THE AUTOBIOGRAPHY OF

Malcolm X

A blueprint for conviction, courage, and transformation.

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BOOK

MAN'S SEARCH FOR MEANING

Viktor Frankl

Finding meaning even in suffering.

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BOOK

THE SCREWTAPE LETTERS

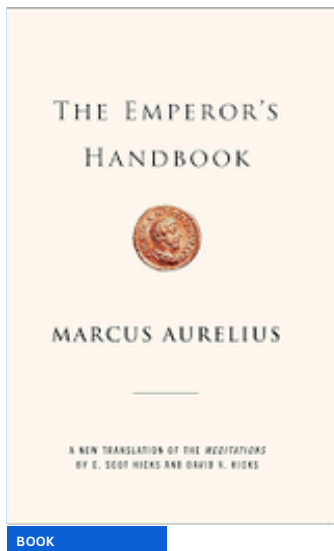
C. S. Lewis

A satirical moral classic written as a series of letters from a Shaytan to his apprentice, revealing how distraction, pride, comfort, and self-deception quietly undermine the inner life;

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LIFE BEFORE DEATH

Spirituality • Mortality • Legacy • Character



BOOK

THE EMPEROR'S HANDBOOK

Marcus Aurelius

Stoic reflections on discipline, duty, and inner mastery from a ruling emperor

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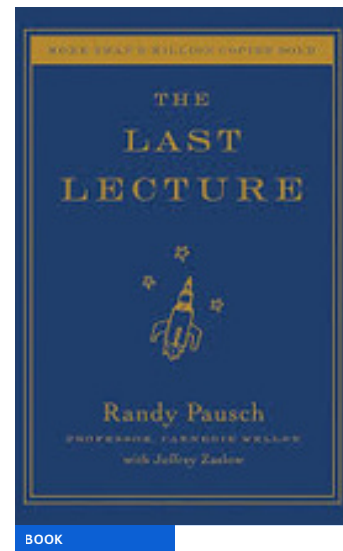
BOOK

REVELATION

Meraj Mohiuddin

A clear, intellectually grounded exploration of the Qur'an's revelation, preservation, and authority.

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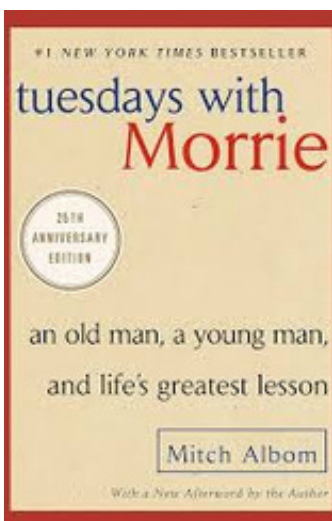
BOOK

THE LAST LECTURE

Randy Pausch

Life lessons from a professor facing terminal illness.

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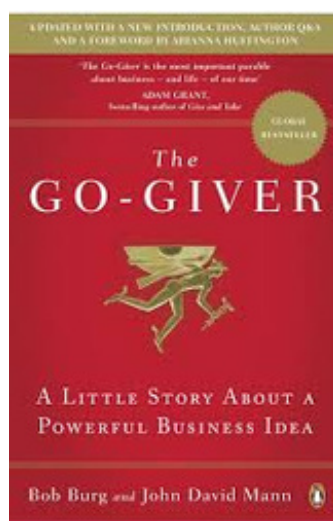
BOOK

TUESDAYS WITH MORRIE

Mitch Albom

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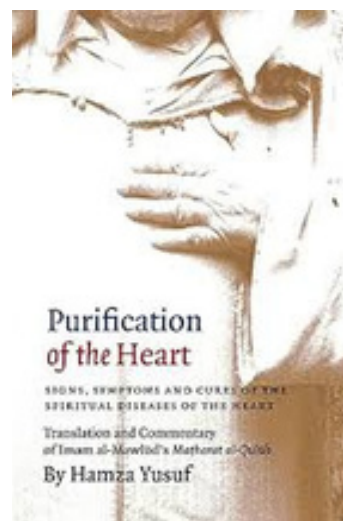
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